The Revelation and The Responsibility

Acts 9:1-19

Intro:

In this week's passage, we see two revelations and two responsibilities. First, Christ reveals Himself to Saul, a persecutor of the church, and then to Ananias, a faithful disciple. Although their circumstances are very different, both are confronted with the authority of Christ and called to submit to Him. This passage speaks to both the unbeliever who is living in rebellion against Christ and the disciple who is already walking with Him. When Christ reveals Himself to us through His Word, His revelation demands a response. Today, we will examine what that response looks like when we first come to know Christ and as we continue walking with Him as His disciples.

V.1-19

"But Saul, **still breathing threats** and **murder** *against the disciples of the Lord*, **went to the high priest and asked** *him for letters to the synagogues at Damascus, so that if he found any belonging to the Way, men or women, he might bring them bound to Jerusalem*. Now as he went on his way, he approached Damascus, and suddenly **a light from heaven shone around him**. *And falling to the ground, he heard a voice saying to him*, "**Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?**" And *he said, "Who are you, Lord?*" And he said, "**I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting**. *But rise and enter the city, and you will be told what you are to do.*" The men who were traveling with him stood speechless, *hearing the voice but seeing no one*. Saul rose from the ground, and **although his eyes were opened, he saw nothing**. So *they led him by the hand and brought him into Damascus*. And **for three days he was without sight**, **and neither ate nor drank**. *Now there was a disciple at Damascus named Ananias*. The Lord said to him in a vision, "Ananias." And he said, "Here I am, Lord." And the Lord said to him, *"Rise and go to the street called Straight, and at the house of Judas look for a man of Tarsus named Saul, for behold, **he is praying**, and he has seen in a vision a man named Ananias come in and lay his hands on him so that he might regain his sight."* But Ananias answered, "**Lord**, **I have heard from many about this man, how much evil he has done to your saints at Jerusalem**. *And here he has authority from the chief priests to bind all who call on your name.*" But the Lord said to him, **"Go, for he is a chosen instrument of mine** *to carry my name before the Gentiles and kings and the children of Israel*. **For I will show him how much he must suffer for the sake of my name.** *So Ananias departed and entered the house*. *And laying his hands on him he said***, "Brother Saul, the Lord Jesus who appeared to you on the road by which you came has sent me so that you may regain your sight and be filled with the Holy Spirit.**" And *immediately something like scales fell from his eyes*, *and he regained his sight*. Then **he rose** and **was baptized**; and *taking food*, *he was strengthened*."

- **Revelation 1: I Am Jesus, Whom You Are Persecuting** (V.5)

Saul believed he was serving God by persecuting the church, but on the road to Damascus, he encounters the risen Christ and discovers that the very One he was fighting against is Lord. Like Saul, all of us either once lived or are still living in rebellion against God. Although we may not actively persecute believers as Saul did, Jesus makes it clear in Matthew 12:30: *"Whoever is not with me is against me, and whoever does not gather with me scatters."* There is no neutrality toward Christ. We are either with Him or against Him.In Acts 26:14, as Paul recounts his conversion, Jesus tells him, *"It is hard for you to kick against the goads."* Using an agricultural metaphor, Jesus illustrates the futility of Saul's resistance. In the same way, when we resist God's authority and insist on directing our own lives, we are fighting against the very One who gives us life, our Good God and Savior who loves us, and ultimately just hurting ourselves. Today, Christ reveals Himself to us through His Word and the proclamation of the gospel (2 Corinthians 4:3–6; Romans 10:14–17). And just as Saul was confronted with the reality of who Jesus is, we too are confronted with this truth: **Jesus Christ is Lord.** The question is, how will we respond to this revelation? Read: Philippians 2:9–11

- **Responsibility 1: Surrender to His Lordship** (V.5,11,18)

When Saul encounters the blinding light and hears the voice asking, *"Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?"* he responds, *"Who are you, Lord?"* Saul recognizes that he is being confronted by someone with authority, and as the account progresses, we see evidence of his submission to Christ. In verse 11, Saul is praying, and in verse 18, he is baptized. The man who once persecuted Christ's followers is now submitting to Christ Himself and publicly identifying with Him through baptism. **The revelation of Jesus Christ as Lord and Savior demands a response.** We can either reject Him and continue in rebellion, or surrender to His lordship as Saul did. We must bow before Him in repentance and faith, recognizing that only Christ can forgive our sins and give us new life. And through baptism, we publicly declare our allegiance to Him. There is no neutrality when it comes to Jesus Christ.

- **Revelation 2: Rise and Go** (V.10-15)

The narrative now shifts to Ananias, whom Luke introduces as a disciple, meaning a follower of Christ. When the Lord commands him to go to Saul of Tarsus, Ananias hesitates because he knows Saul's reputation as a persecutor of the church. But the Lord makes it clear that, regardless of Saul's past, He has chosen him as His instrument and commands Ananias to go. As disciples of Christ, we have received this same calling through Scripture. In Matthew 28:18–20, Jesus commands us to go and make disciples of all nations. We are not called to decide who is worthy of hearing the gospel based on their past or present opposition to Christ. **God is sovereign over salvation; our responsibility is to faithfully proclaim the gospel and make disciples.** We are called to rise and go, trusting Him with the results.

- **Responsibility 2: Obey His Calling** (V.17)

Despite his initial hesitation, Ananias obeys the Lord and goes to Saul. As disciples, our submission to Christ does not end at salvation; it continues throughout our lives as we seek to glorify Him and make disciples. And this passage shows us not only the importance of obedience but also the heart with which we should approach others. Two details stand out. First, Ananias lays his hands on Saul. The very man who had persecuted believers is now being approached with compassion and care. Although the laying on of hands has a specific purpose in this account, we can draw a practical application from Ananias's willingness to personally approach someone he once feared. We too are called to show kindness, mercy, and love, even toward those who oppose us.

Second, Ananias addresses him as *"Brother Saul."* I love this because Ananias gives Saul the benefit of the doubt, trusting what the Lord has revealed about him rather than holding his past against him. And I think this is something we often struggle with as believers. We tend to assume the worst of others while assuming the best of ourselves. But 1 Corinthians 13:7 tells us that love *"believes all things."* This doesn't mean love is naive or ignores the truth, but that it is willing to give others the benefit of the doubt rather than immediately assuming the worst. Ananias knew Saul's past, but he trusted God's word and received him as a brother. We must learn to approach others with that same love, grace, and compassion. Read: Ephesians 4:31–32,

Main Idea:

When Christ reveals Himself to us through His Word, His revelation demands a response. We are called to surrender to Him as Lord and continue walking in obedience, making disciples and showing others the same love and mercy He has shown us.

